GROSS DOMESTIC BEHAVIOUR

METHODOLOGY

The India Today Group, in collaboration with How India Lives (HIL) and Kadence International, conducted India's first 'Gross Domestic Behaviour' survey to study social and personal behaviours across the country.

- It covered 9,188 respondents from 98 districts across 21 states and one Union Territory
- The sample included 50.8 per cent male and 49.2 per cent female respondents
- They were also split as 54.4 per cent urban and 45.6 per cent rural respondents.

Since no single measurement could fully capture the diverse social and personal behaviours, the survey used multiple factors grouped into four broad themes:

- **Civic Behaviour** (participation in community activities, following public rules) – 12 questions
- **Public Safety** (trust in law enforcement, personal security perceptions) – 6 questions
- **Gender Attitudes** (views on gender roles and equality) – 7 questions
- **Diversity and Discrimination** (biases based on caste, religion, or ethnicity) – 5 questions.

A total of 30 questions were asked, with variations for urban and rural respondents. To rank states on these themes and overall, two indices were created using the following process:

SCORES OF QUESTIONS

To calculate scores for each question, individual survey responses from all 9,188 respondents were first aggregated to determine what percentage of respondents selected each answer option (Strongly Agree, Somewhat Agree, Somewhat Disagree, or Strongly Disagree). These aggregated percentages—not individual responses—were then used in the weighting formulas described below to calculate scores for each question. Each question was then categorised by whether agreement or disagreement represented a positive response.

For questions where agreement indicated a positive behaviour—for instance, "Should daughters in the family be encouraged to study or pursue education as much as sons?"—response percentages were weighted to reflect their strength. The percentage of respondents who "Strongly Agree" was assigned a full weight of 1 point, while the percentage who "Somewhat Agree" was given a lower weight of 0.3 points to acknowledge partial agreement while prioritising stronger convictions. The final score for each question was calculated using the formula: (1 × % of respondents who strongly agree) + (0.3 × % of respondents who somewhat agree), ensuring stronger opinions had a greater influence on the overall index.

Similarly, for questions where disagreement was the preferred response, such as rejecting wife-beating, the scoring used disagreement percentages to ensure alignment with the intended direction of the question. The percentage of respondents who "Strongly Disagree" was assigned a full weight of 1 point, while the percentage who "Somewhat Disagree" was given a lower weight of 0.3 points. This ensured that stronger opposition to undesirable behaviours carried more influence in the final score while still accounting for partial disagreement.

THEME INDICES

For each theme:

- Question scores were converted to a 0–1 scale based on the highest and lowest scores across all states using normalisation technique
- Each normalised score received equal weight within its theme (1/N, where N is the number of questions)
- Weighted normalised scores summed up to create the theme index
- Rural and urban indices were calculated separately, then combined using population weights, e.g., (Rural Theme Index × % Rural Population) + (Urban Theme Index × % Urban Population).

COMPOSITE INDEX

The overall composite index was created by:

- Giving equal weight to each theme and to questions within each theme (like in theme index)
- Summing all weighted question scores separately for rural and urban respondents
- Combining these rural and urban composite indices using population weights: (Rural Composite × % Rural Population) + (Urban Composite × % Urban Population)..

HOW THE STATES WERE RANKED

Based on these indices, states were ranked individually for each theme, as well as in a combined ranking that reflected their overall performance across different social indicators. Higher index values indicate more socially positive responses, resulting in better rankings. All index values and intermediary scores don't have any intrinsic meaning as they are relative values based on the maximum and minimum among the states. Hence we publish only rank ordering and not the index values as they can be misconstrued.

LIMITATIONS

- The limited sample size and complex survey design resulted in estimates with higher variance (low precision), so trends are more reliable than absolute estimates
- Question selection reflects the commissioning entity's perspective
- Determining whether agreement or disagreement constitutes a "positive" response involves subjective judgement
- The weighting choices (equal weights for themes and questions, 0.3 weight for "somewhat" responses) are inherently subjective
- Index values are relative rather than absolute, making rankings more meaningful than actual scores. ■

For the detailed report, please scan the QR code